Working with your dentist during cancer care

Check for updates

Oral health concerns may not come to mind when you are facing cancer, but they should. Oral complications are common during cancer treatment, especially treatments for head and neck cancer. Oral health problems associated with cancer treatments include

- oral sores or infections
- tooth decay
- gum problems
- taste disturbances
- jaw stiffness

SEEING YOUR DENTIST BEFORE CANCER TREATMENT

The National Cancer Institute recommends a complete dental examination a month before beginning cancer treatment.[1] This may provide time to treat problems like decay, gum disease, or oral sores or infections. This appointment also may identify damage to existing fillings, poor-fitting dentures, or jaw problems. Your dentist also may prescribe artificial saliva or fluoride rinses to use during cancer treatment.

ORAL HEALTH DURING CANCER TREATMENT

There are steps you can take before and during your cancer treatment that may help improve your oral health.

Good oral care may reduce the risk of developing cavities and keep your gums healthy.

- Brush your teeth twice per day, for 2 minutes each time. Use a soft-bristled toothbrush, making gentle, toothwide circles along the gumline.
- Use a fluoride toothpaste since fluoride helps strengthen enamel.
- Gently clean between your teeth once per day using dental floss, tape, a water flosser, a floss holder, or another product designed for that use.
- If you develop mouth sores, use a rinse every 2 hours to decrease soreness in the mouth: dissolve one-quarter teaspoon of salt and one-quarter teaspoon of baking soda in 1 quart of water.
- Look for the American Dental Association (ADA) Seal of Acceptance on dental products (Figure). Products with the ADA Seal of Acceptance have been proven to be safe and effective when used as directed.
- Avoid sugary foods and drinks.

Many cancer treatments cause dry mouth. Here are some things you can try to moisten your mouth

- Sip water or sugarless drinks that do not contain caffeine.
- Suck on (do not chew) ice chips.
- Apply lanolin-based lip balm often.
- Use sugar-free chewing gum or sugar-free candy to stimulate saliva production.
- Avoid salty or spicy foods.
- Limit alcoholic beverages.
- If you use a mouthrinse, choose one that is alcohol free.
- Use a humidifier at night.



Figure. The American Dental Association (ADA) Seal of Acceptance appears on dental products that have been proven to be safe and effective. Many of these products also include a list of their dental benefits along with the seal.

CONCLUSION

Oral effects of cancer treatments can make you uncomfortable and damage your health. Working together with your dentist may help limit these effects. Make sure your dentist is aware of changes in your health and treatments so that he or she can help you during your cancer care. ■

DISCLOSURE

Ms. Mark did not report any disclosures.

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.adaj.2024.08.002

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"For the Patient" provides general information on dental treatments. It is designed to prompt discussion between dentist and patient about treatment options and does not substitute for the dentist's professional assessment based on the individual patient's needs and desires.

You can find more information for patients at ADAstore.org or at MouthHealthy.org.

1. Oral complications of cancer therapies: patient version. National Cancer Institute. Accessed August 11, 2024. https://www.cancer.gov/about-cancer/treatment/side-effects/mouth-throat/oral-complications-pdq#section/_9